

PERSONIFICATION

Giving human qualities to non-human things



1 What is it?

Personification (per-son-if-ih-KAY-shun)

Personification gives **human actions, feelings or qualities** to something that isn't human — an object, an animal, an idea, even the weather.

non-human thing + human action/feeling

2 See it in action

The weather

The wind howled angrily through the empty streets.

An object

The old floorboards groaned and complained under his weight.

An idea

Opportunity only knocks once, so answer the door.

Nature

The sun smiled down on the sleepy village.



You got this!

Look for a **human verb** (like "whispered", "groaned", "smiled") attached to something that can't actually do that — that verb is your giveaway.

FUN FACT

Personification is everywhere in idioms you already use — "time flies," "my alarm clock betrayed me," "opportunity knocks" — you've been using this technique in conversation without even noticing!

3 Why writers use it

Personification helps writers: make non-human things feel alive, relatable and emotionally charged — it helps readers connect with a scene by imagining it has feelings just like they do.

It's especially powerful for setting a mood: an "angry" storm feels more threatening than a storm that's just described as loud and wet.

4 Don't mix it up!

Personification

- Gives **human** traits
- To a **non-human** thing
- "The trees **waved** at us."

Pathetic Fallacy

- A type of personification
- Only for **weather/nature**
- Reflects a character's **mood**



Watch out!

Careful with animals — describing an animal doing something it **CAN** actually do (a dog "barking angrily") isn't personification. It only counts when you give something a trait it **can't** really have.



Good spot!

When you spot personification, always ask **why that particular human trait** was chosen — a "screaming" wind feels very different from a "singing" one.

5 Quick recap

Gives human qualities

To something non-human

Makes things feel alive



Keep going!

Try it yourself: pick an everyday object near you and give it a human feeling — "the kettle grumbled as it boiled" is all it takes!